

Document 12: Leprosy - Symptoms and Control

Leprosy, also known as Hansen's disease, is a chronic infectious disease caused by *Mycobacterium leprae*. It primarily affects the skin, peripheral nerves, and mucous membranes. Early symptoms include discolored skin patches, numbness, and muscle weakness. If untreated, leprosy can lead to severe deformities and disability. The disease is transmitted through prolonged close contact with an untreated person. Early diagnosis and multidrug therapy (MDT) are highly effective in curing leprosy and preventing complications. Public health programs focus on reducing stigma and promoting early treatment.